The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

The **Trump** administration fast-tracked $8.6bn in arms sales to America's allies in the Middle East, including the UAE, Israel and Qatar. Invoking an emergency authorisation, the State Department bypassed Congress, which typically approves such sales. Earlier Donald Trump told Congress that hostilities with Iran "have terminated" ahead of a deadline that would have required lawmakers' permission to continue the war after 60 days of fighting.

Berkshire Hathaway reported first-quarter operating profit of $11.4bn—an 18% year-on-year increase. Several parts of the sprawling conglomerate contributed to the higher earnings, including its retail, manufacturing and insurance divisions. Its cash pile grew from $371bn to $397bn, its highest ever level. The results mark a strong start to Greg Abel's tenure as boss, who took over from Warren Buffett in January.

The Pentagon announced that it would remove 5,000 troops from **Germany** after a spat between Mr Trump and Friedrich Merz. Germany's chancellor said on Monday that America was being "humiliated" by Iran's leaders. Earlier Mr Trump said he would increase tariffs on cars from the EU to 25%, from 15% currently,

and accused the bloc of “not complying” with a trade deal struck last year.

Spirit Airlines ceased operations after failing to secure a $500m bailout from the Trump administration. The low-cost carrier said it was working to get stranded employees home and passengers refunds. It filed for its second bankruptcy last year amid growing competition and a blocked merger with JetBlue; soaring energy prices have caused additional strain.

Somali pirates hijacked an oil tanker off the coast of **Yemen**, according to the BBC. Yemen’s coast guard confirmed that the MT Eureka, which was flying under the flag of Togo, was seized in the Gulf of Aden and heading towards Somalia. Ten days ago Somali pirates hijacked a different oil tanker in the area.

Oleksandr Syrsky, the head of **Ukraine’s** army, said Russian forces had nearly reached the outskirts of **Kostiantynivka**, one of several fortified towns in the eastern Donetsk region. The “fortress belt” of towns span a defensive line holding Russia back from the 19% of the region still controlled by Ukraine. Mr Syrsky said Ukrainian forces had repulsed “persistent attempts” by Russian troops to infiltrate the city.

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain’s prime minister, told the BBC that some **protests** may be stopped in the wake of an **antisemitic attack** in London. Some Jewish leaders have called for pro-Palestinian marches to be temporarily halted. On Wednesday a man stabbed two Jewish men in Golders Green, an area with a big Jewish population. Police arrested a suspect at the scene; the victims survived with serious injuries.

Word of the week: *Döstädning*, “death-cleaning”, the Swedish practice of decluttering before death to spare loved ones from having to do so afterwards. Read more in our obituary of Margareta Magnusson, who brought the concept to the rest of the world.

Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

Berkshire’s big bash

Berkshire Hathaway’s annual meeting in Omaha, Nebraska is a jamboree of adoring middle-class capitalists. It is the opposite of gambling-adjacent retail trading, but just as fun. The meeting in 2015 began with a video of Warren Buffett, the company’s totemic boss who retired at the end of last year, boxing Floyd Mayweather. There are also newspaper-tossing competitions.

When Mr Buffett stepped down Berkshire held tradeable stocks, bonds and cash worth nearly $700bn, and controlled around 200 companies. His successor, Greg Abel, is not a born stock-picker, having risen through the energy business. Investors want to know what he will do with Berkshire’s cash pile, which has grown to $397bn. At Saturday’s meeting, titled “The Legacy Continues”, Mr Abel tried to reassure the faithful that he will stick to Mr Buffett’s formula of spotting and investing in businesses with a competitive advantage. That would be wise. After all, the 95-year-old Mr Buffett is still chairman of the board.

Photograph: Getty Images

No rest for the regal

With the hard part of his transatlantic trip completed to rave reviews from Donald Trump, King Charles may have hoped for a holiday from tricky diplomacy on the second leg, to Bermuda, from where he flies home on Saturday.

Fat chance, your majesty. Although relations between Britain's government and Bermuda, home to 63,000 of his subjects, are not as tense as those with the Trump administration, not all has been smooth. Britain wants to constrain the secret offshore practices of its dependent territories, which serve as tax havens. The government wants Bermuda to introduce publicly accessible registers of the "beneficial ownership" of offshore companies, revealing who actually controls them (often different from the legal, or titular, owner).

Bermuda has resisted, citing privacy concerns. Last year, Britain's foreign office told Bermuda to fall in line "as soon as possible". It is particularly irked by reports that islands such as Bermuda are a conduit for sanctioned Russian trade.

Photograph: Reuters

Tough sledding for Alberta’s separatists

A separatist group in Alberta, an energy-rich province in Canada, has gathered enough signatures to force a referendum on independence ahead of a deadline on Saturday. Even if the vote goes ahead, support appears limited. Several polls suggest less than 30% of Alberta’s 5.1m people would vote in favour of leaving Canada’s federation.

However the bigger obstacle to “Wexit”, as the western province’s independence movement has been dubbed, may be the courts. This week a judge ordered a separatist group to take down a public, searchable database containing “extremely sensitive” personal information on millions of voters in the province, dealing a blow to its campaign infrastructure. On April 10th, another judge imposed a one-month pause on verifying the signatures for the referendum petition while courts assess whether independence would violate First Nations’s rights. If they find that it would, the push for a referendum could be blocked altogether.

Photograph: AP

Shakira takes the stage in Rio

Some 2m people are expected to gather on Copacabana beach in Rio de Janeiro on Saturday to see a performance by Shakira, a Latin American pop legend, for free. It will be the third time that the Brazilian city's local government, with corporate sponsors, has funded a mega-show for the public: in 2024 Madonna held her biggest concert ever on the beach, and last year almost 2m revellers partied until dawn with Lady Gaga. The mayor who started the shows has promised to keep putting them on until at least 2028, because "it fills up all the hotels and all the restaurants."

Rio has experienced a boom in tourism, thanks to online traction on Instagram and to large numbers of visitors from Argentina, Brazil's most populous neighbour. Despite violence and corruption, visitors enjoy the city's paradisiacal landscapes and peach-tinged sunsets—and its love of dancing whenever, wherever, as Shakira once sang.

Photograph: AP

Weekend profile: Zack Polanski, Britain's hypnotic eco-populist

On a typical day Zack Polanski likes his first post on Bluesky, a social-media site, at around 8.30am. His favourite times to scroll are between noon and 1pm, and from 6pm to 7pm. His last like usually happens around 11.15pm. After that, presumably, it's bedtime. The 43-year-old leader of the Green Party of England and Wales has liked almost 35,000 posts on Bluesky since April 2025. His hit rate has not slowed since he became leader in September. On May 1st Mr Polanski apologised for "sharing a tweet in haste", after he reposted a comment on X that questioned how police officers treated a man suspected of stabbing two Jewish men in north London. But he has been causing a stir offline too.

Mr Polanski, a forceful communicator, has shaken off the Greens' middle-class reputation. In February the party caused an upset when its candidate, a 34-year-old female plumber, won a parliamentary by-election in Greater Manchester. In local elections on May 7th it thinks it can win 1,000 council seats, one-in-five of those up for grabs; it is doing especially well in London.

Mr Polanski is a latecomer to electoral politics. He grew up in Manchester in a Jewish family, came out as gay as a teenager and spent two decades as an actor, boosting his income with odd jobs including hypnotherapist. In 2013 he told a reporter that he could

enlarge her breasts using “the unconscious” (he has since apologised). Two years later he joined the centrist Liberal Democrats but failed to mesmerise voters, standing unsuccessfully to be a councillor in London. He switched to the Greens in 2017. Eventually he was elected to the London Assembly, where he still sits.

The Economist’s poll tracker puts the Greens just three points behind Labour and the Conservatives, Britain’s two traditional parties of government. (Reform UK, a populist-right party led by Nigel Farage, is ahead of them all.) That is partly down to Labour, which in government has turned left-wing voters off. Much of it is thanks to Mr Polanski’s flashy policies, which include a wealth tax on billionaires, rent controls and maximum-pay ratios. The party has embraced “eco-populism”—emphasising social justice as much as climate change. Its lavish spending plans would be toxic for Britain’s economy.

Mr Polanski has reached voters with some unusual campaigning, including nightclub appearances (though he says he has never drunk alcohol or taken recreational drugs). He’s a fan of cheesy jokes and can be quick to make fun of himself. Yet he also seems thin-skinned, at least online. Dozens of posts he has liked include personal insults about journalists who have written about him. The party says “He is sorry for any mistakes made when working fast.” For now, Mr Polanski and the Greens show no sign of slowing down.

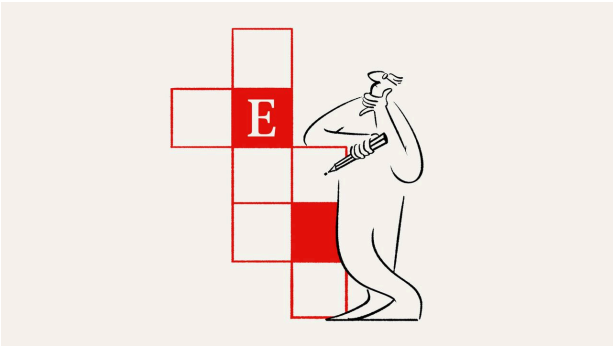

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Lineage without a stroke delivers vital fluid (5)

2 across - Russian vector's opposite drops hesitation, then recoils (4)

3 across - Pre-raphaelite ultimately was first class (5)

1 down - It's May Day! Running wild is tenable (7)

Straight clues

1 across - Thicker than the water of the womb (5)

2 across - The last one was Nicholas II (4)

3 across - Internet slang "l33t" derives from this word (5)

1 down - Gaelic festival held on first of May (7)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Isabelle de Hennin, Brussels, Belgium

Ahmed Alsuwaidi, Dubai, United Arab Emirates

Sulaiman Penseney, Victoria, Canada

They gave the correct answers of Doctor Doom, shire horse, the middle, the Petronas Towers and Billie Jean King. The theme is The Lord of the Rings books and films which feature Mount Doom and the Shire, are set in Middle-earth and have titles The Two Towers and The Return of the King.

The questions were:

Monday: Which character is the main archenemy of the Fantastic Four, in both the comic book and film series?

Tuesday: Which breed of horse, originating in England, was notable for its strength, being used to pull canal boats and brewers' carts, as well as farm equipment?

Wednesday: The median appears at which point of a statistical distribution?

Thursday: Which buildings in Malaysia were the world's tallest from 1998 to 2004?

Friday: Which female tennis player took part in the Battle of the Sexes match against Bobby Riggs in 1973?

The noblest pleasure is the joy of understanding.

Leonardo Da Vinci